

	Document Type:	DOCUMENTED INFORMATION ISO 9001:2015	Document Code	RES- RP-01
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(1) Research Program/Project/Study Title: "Looking Through their Eyes": A Case Study of Visually Impaired College Students	
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Program or Project has component (if no proceed to 2)? ☐ Yes ☒ No

Component Title:	
Component Leader:	
Academic Rank:	

(2) Category (please check) ☒ Social Science/Education /Humanities & other related fields ☐ Natural/BiologicalSciences ☐ Food Research/ ☐ Developmental/ Computer/Engineering/ Architecture ☐ Extension ☐ Poster	(3) Research Center [Check the concerned center] ☒ SSITRDC Social Science and Industrial Technology Research Development Center ☐ LRDC Livestock Research Development Center ☐ FFRDC Fisheries and Food Research Development Center ☐ CSRDC Crop Science Research Development Center
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(4) Site of implementation	
Municipality/City:	
Province:	Capiz
Region:	VI

(5) Classification <table> <tr> <td>Research:</td> <td>Development:</td> </tr> <tr> <td>☒ Basic</td> <td>☐ Pilot Testing</td> </tr> <tr> <td>☒ Applied</td> <td>☐ Tech. Promotion/Commercialization</td> </tr> </table>	Research:	Development:	☒ Basic	☐ Pilot Testing	☒ Applied	☐ Tech. Promotion/Commercialization	(6) Mode of Implementation ☐ Single Authorship/Proponent ☐ Collaborative Research (within campus) ☒ Collaborative Research (intercampus) ☐ Collaborative Research (external agency)
Research:	Development:						
☒ Basic	☐ Pilot Testing						
☒ Applied	☐ Tech. Promotion/Commercialization						

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(7) Sector/Commodity Visually Impaired Students and Graduates	(8) Discipline/Field of Specialization Social Science
(9) Rationale Inclusive education has been adopted to ensure the quality of and right to education for all learners and is now a contemporary educational approach recognized globally (United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities, 2016). Inclusive education is a philosophy that brings stakeholders together to create school environment based on acceptance and belonging with in the school and the community (Salend, 2011). It aims to mainstream students with special needs in a flexible learning environment for acquiring quality education that optimizes their potential for holistic development (Dela Fuente, J., 2021). The worldwide initiative to welcome disabled students on university campuses is fairly new (Redpath et al., 2013). In the traditional educational landscape, it is very hard for the disabled students to obtain a tertiary degree (Lourens, H. & Swartz, L., 2019). The paradigm shift to inclusive education challenges the higher education institutions in the Philippines. Thus, to become responsive in the implementation of inclusive education, the Commission on Higher Education (CHED) circulated CHED Memorandum Order 23, s. 2000, known as Quality Education for Learners with Special Needs (CHED, 2000; 2017) which urged higher education institutions to admit students with special needs, include SPED programs for teacher training institutions, and provide or modified accessible facilities and equipment for students with special needs including those with visual impairment. The higher educational institutions as the apex in the educational career are expected to play major role to equip the individual with the maximum intellectual and physical skills to be an innovative, creative, and self-reliant, able to cope with the economic and cultural demands of the society. According to Omede (2015), intellectual potentials of the visually impaired which are developed through higher education makes them contributors not only to the national but the global economy like their sighted counterparts. In the Province of Capiz, only very few visually impaired students were accepted in the Higher Education Institutions (HEIs). In the study of Tonel (2019), on the five (5) private higher education institutions (HEIs) and one (1) public university with nine (9) campuses in the province, all CHED supervised learning institutions, only eighteen (18) visually impaired were accepted in the higher learning of education. Viewing the literature and data presented, there is a limited study conducted on the in-depth understanding of the struggles and difficulties experienced by the visually impaired students in taking a college degree in the locality. These predicaments captured the interest of the researchers to conduct a study in order to understand the experiences of the visually impaired students in the mainstream education in the province of Capiz. Hence, this study is necessary.	
(9-A) Project Description	
(10) Objectives/Statement of the Problem This study will aim to understand the lived-experiences of the visually impaired students in the mainstream education system of higher education. Specifically, the study will seek to answer the following questions: 1. What are the motivating factors for the participants in entering the mainstream tertiary education? 2. What are the struggles experienced by the participants as they enter into the mainstream of formal Education system? 3. How do they overcome the challenges and struggles in their quest for education? 4. How do they adapt to the social, academic and physical environment in the mainstream education system? 5. What plan of action can be drawn from the result of the study?	
(11) Review of Literature/Prior Art Search	

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The Inclusive Education

Inscribed in the Universal Declaration on Human Rights (1984), education is a basic right. A range of declarations and conventions highlight the importance of education for people with disabilities: the Salamanca Statement on education and special needs in 1994, as well as article 24 of the United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities adopted in 2006. The Inclusive Education is a learning environment where children with and without disabilities are taught together, as equals. The goal of an inclusive education system is to provide all students with the most appropriate learning environments and opportunities for them to best achieve their potential (Opie, 2018). The term inclusion ensures that all students, regardless of ability or disability, can participate successfully in the mainstream of education by adapting the regular school curriculum, teaching methods, organization, and resources need. The fundamental principle of the inclusive school is that all children should learn together, despite any difficulties they may have. These schools should respond to the diverse needs of their students, ensuring quality education for all students through modified curricula, teaching strategies, and provisions, and resource use (Inciong & Quijano, 2013).

Problems and Barriers to Inclusive Education

Major barriers to the provision of quality education for children with disabilities in all educational environments consist of the lack of early intervention services, inflexible curriculum and assessment procedures, negative attitudes, inadequate training, a lack of specialist support staff to assist s of special and regular classes, a lack of appropriate teaching equipment and learning devices, and failure to make modifications to the school environment to make it fully accessible. All these obstacles can be overcome through planning and implementing a practical policy (Mona Ahmad Kazim, 2007). Poorly adapted infrastructures and a lack of accessible learning materials are significant obstacles. This is particularly true in rural areas where increased levels of poverty, poor services, and recurrent infrastructure failings exacerbate these existing problems for children with disabilities (SADPD, 2012). School curricula that solely rely on passive learning methods, such as drilling, dictation, and copying from the blackboard, further limit access to quality education for children with disabilities (Humanity & Inclusion, 2015).

It is generally acknowledged that children and adolescents with disabilities often encounter additional adversities, disadvantages, and difficulties during their development, and experience exclusion from age-appropriate. For this reason, interventions and practices aiming to enhance resilience may be particularly beneficial for these children, provided that their access to and equal participation in them are ensured (Hart et al., 2014). Providing integration and equal higher educational opportunities for the visually impaired in this country is sometimes controversial due to environmental degradation, architectural barriers, negative attitude of the public, inadequate materials/ equipment, cost of education and high cost of the materials invoiced for the effective teaching and learning (Omede, 2015). People with disabilities including people with visual impairments experienced severe forms of discrimination, isolation and separation. They were perceived as people with deficits and in need of help.

One of the challenges of inclusive education is providing culturally relevant and viable in-services training to all teachers, with consideration for the varied and often difficult conditions under which they serve (Inciong & Quijano, 2013). Issues faced concerning teaching staff include the practical feasibility of inclusion, classroom teacher demands, the quality of support for students, and the degree of knowledge, understanding, and expertise required by classroom teachers (Botha & Kourkoutas, 2016). The uncertainty and time-consuming nature of identifying different approaches when providing support, the place of alternative settings and services for the inclusion of students with special needs have also received criticism from some educators (Hulgin & Drake, 2011).

Coping Mechanisms

According to Tiersley-Dixon & Frederickson (2016), students with special educational needs who receive social support in inclusive settings may have similar levels of social inclusion to their typically developing classmates. These students actively seek social support from staff members and peers, but they face many challenges, such as the lack of training and awareness. Support from staff members contributes to students' academic learning and social inclusion, whereas peers' social support enhances their self-esteem and social acceptance (Manitsa, I., & Doikou, M., 2020).

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Meanwhile, Joseph (2010) mentioned that in the attainment of a college degree for a student who is visually impaired is not a simple process. There have been many obstacles and barriers to overcome in the higher education system. Some visually impaired students find it challenging getting around campus. For them, the physical environment is potentially dangerous (Lourens, H., & Swartz, L. (2016). For example, they spoke about the threat of motor vehicles and obstructions in the environment. Obstructions in the environment included holes in sidewalks, low-hanging branches and road works. It was difficult for the visually impaired students to familiarize themselves with a new environment. They often experienced emotional distress as they walked through large crowds of students, tried to keep out of harm's way and tried to find their classrooms (Lourens, H., & Swartz, L. (2016).

In Yonson (2018), visually impaired students developed a certain adaptive mechanism that enables them to survive their academic journey. Their difficulty taught them to innovate themselves to become accustomed to the growing demand of society for them to be equally competitive and productive individual that does not consider their difficulties as hindrance. Visually impaired students who are in the mainstream classes have a stronger socio-academic adaptability which enables them to relate themselves to their mainstream counterparts and to excel in their academics.

Grove (2020), pointed out that visually impaired students showed strong determination and self-advocacy to earn their bachelor's degree despite both seen and unseen barriers (Grove (2020). Topor & Roseblum (2013) mentioned that students with visual impairment don't have any serious problems associated to listening and speaking. In fact, listening is the primary learning method for blind students and a strong helpful tool for visually-impaired students. Students with visual impairments often experience emotional problems and encounter difficulties in forming and maintaining social relationships. The social support provided to these students by staff members and their peers in educational institutions may have a positive impact on their academic learning and socio-emotional development (Manitsa, I., & Doikou, M., 2020).

Omede (2015), recommended on his study on the challenges of educating visually impaired students in the tertiary level that the school environment should be free from architectural barriers and environmental degradation. This could be achieved by adopting an architectural design of the visually impaired. The social support that students with visual impairments receive at school from their teachers and peers may promote their future independent living (Celeste & Grum, 2010). The development of social relationships and friendships with their classmates may also have a positive impact on their self-esteem and self-confidence (Lindsay & McPherson, 2012). Moreover, social support is positively related to social skills, since the latter allows the individual to seek and maintain social support (Elliott et al., 2001 in Manitsa & Doikou, 2020). In addition, the development of the sense of belonging and acceptance in the school environment, and the provision of instrumental and emotional support from teachers and peers have a positive impact on students' well-being and they are considered fundamental components of inclusive education (Manitsa & Doikou, 2020).

Despite of some barriers encountered by the visually impaired students, Inciong & Quijano (2013) mentioned that children with visual impairments have been found to perform academically well with their regular peers with whom they get along harmoniously. In the study of Muwanguzi & Lin (2010), results showed that the blind students were motivated and optimistic of their successes despite their frustrations and feelings of marginalization.

(12) Scientific Basis/Theoretical Framework

Epistemological and Theoretical Research Perspective

This study will be anchored in the epistemology of constructionism. The people are responsible in constructing their own understanding and knowledge of the world through experiencing things and reflecting those experiences (Crotty, 2003). Using this perspective, it is expected that the information gathered from the participants will pave a way to a better understanding on how the visually impaired individuals survived and succeeded in their chosen field of education despite of the challenges they encountered in the mainstream education system.

Interpretivism stresses that people are deliberate and creative in their actions, they act intentionally and make meanings in and through their activity; they actively construct their social world; and the social world is studied in its natural state without the intervention of, or the manipulation by the researcher (Becker, 1970, Hamersley and Atkinson, 1983, in Ahmed, 2008). In this study, interpretivism attempted to give meaning to the experiences of the participants based on what they think as real

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knowledge.

The theoretical perspective of this study will be further explained by the social model of disability coined by Michael James Hoiles Oliver(1983). According to this model, disability is socially constructed, is a way of viewing the world developed by disabled people. The social model sees 'disability' as the result of the interaction between people living with impairments and an environment filled with physical, attitudinal, communication and social barriers. It therefore carries the implication that the physical, attitudinal, communication and social environment must change to enable people living with impairments to participate in society on an equal basis with others. The lived experiences of the students in the mainstream education will be anchored to this model where the visually impaired students will be given the chance to prove to the world that being a visually impaired individual cannot stop them from emerging into the society surrounded by the visually abled individuals and giving them equal respect due to all human.

In this study, the social environment and the educational institutions where the students were mainstreamed must be responsive to some major changes, adjustment and the provision of support for inclusion of the visually impaired students. This is where inclusive education must be strengthened in all Higher Education Institutions (HEIs). Visually impaired students will be given the chance to enrolled and finish a degree of their choice in the tertiary level of education when the school environment, including the curricular offerings, teaching pedagogies, school physical facilities, accommodation processes, student basic services and social acceptance in the school community, will be meet.

Another important theory that can best support the theoretical underpinning of the study is the theory of inclusion. UNESCO (2005; in Gebrehiwot, 2015) defined inclusion as a "process of addressing and responding to the diversity of needs of all learners through increasing participation in learning, cultures and communities, and reducing exclusion within and from education". It emphasizes giving equal opportunity for students with disabilities to participate in education. Visually impaired students who were considered as part of the marginalized sector of the society will be enrolled and included in the formal educational setting together with their non-disabled peers or classmates to address the basic rights of the disabled persons to full access in education.

The normalization theory by Wolfensberger (1980; in Maindi, 2018), involves the acceptance of people with disabilities with their disabilities, offering them the same conditions as are offered to other citizens. It involves the normal conditions of life – housing, schooling, employment, exercise, recreation and freedom of choice. People with learning disabilities were often rejected and socially excluded from mainstream society but it could be countered through inclusion and creating opportunities to take on valued social roles, in family, society, employment and even in education. These would help to see people with learning disabilities as valued individuals, changing the presumption that those with learning disabilities are fundamentally different. In this study, visually impaired students when given opportunity to have education, in a normal setting, they can have access to employment and can take some major role in the society that can give them the chance to live and perceived to have a normal way of life. By allowing them to enroll and compete academically in the mainstream education, is like treating them as normal individual as their visual counterparts.

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Research Framework

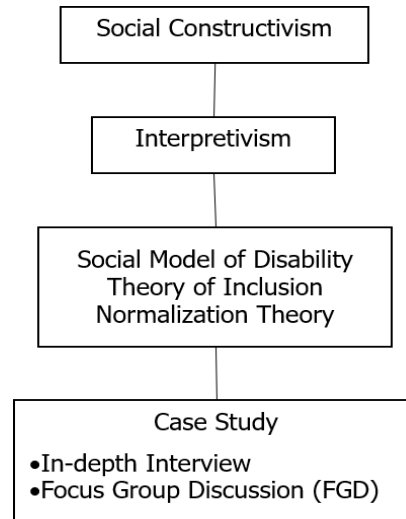


Figure 1. Framework showing the flow of the study

(13) Methodology

This research will employ a qualitative case study approach. It is a strategy of inquiry in which the researcher explores in depth a program, event, activity, process, or one or more individuals (Creswell, 2009). According to Sharan Merriam (2009), a case study approach is an intensive, holistic description and analysis of a bounded phenomenon such as program, an institution, a person, a process or a unit. It is an approach to research that facilitates exploration of a phenomenon within a context using a variety of data sources. Stake (1995) emphasized that cases are bounded by time and activity, and researchers collect detailed information using a variety of data collection procedures over a sustained period of time.

Qualitative case study is particularly suitable methodology for dealing with critical problems of practice and in which understanding is sought in order to improve practice. It further answers the 'how' and 'why' questions. According to Stake (1995), the 'case' is the unit of analysis or a bounded system. The case refers to the object of the case study identified as the entity of interest or unit of analysis. This includes program, individual, group, social situation, organization, event, phenomena or process (Merriam, 2009). In this study, the researcher will explore the experiences of visually impaired college students in the mainstream education amidst their physical disabilities. This design will seek to satisfy the following conditions: a) awareness on the struggles and difficulties experienced by the participants; b) serves as measures on the part of higher education institutions in handling visually impaired students; and c) the practice can be replicated in other similar institutions of learning outside and in the neighboring provinces. This methodology will aim to arrive at a comprehensive understanding of the case under study and for recommendation to the policy making body for the legal adoption of the program and practices beneficial to the visually impaired students. Therefore, in this study the unique and shared experiences of visually impaired students who will participate in the study will be explored.

Participants

The participants will be the visually impaired college students and graduates of any degree course in higher education institutions (HEI's) in the province of Capiz who will be chosen using the following inclusion criteria: (a) must be a student or graduate of any 4-year course; (b) study or earned a degree as part of the mainstream education designed for visual students; (c) ages 18-35 years old; (d) enrolled or graduates of any Higher Education Institutions (HEIs) in the province of Capiz; and (e) willing to participate in the study as confirmed by their signatures in the Informed Consent Forms (ICFs).

Locale of the Study

The study will be conducted in the province of Capiz for the academic year 2021-2022. The

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visually impaired students at present and those who were graduates from the different Higher Education Institutions (HEI's) in the province of Capiz who became part of the mainstream education will be the participants of the study.

Instruments

The researcher will utilized a researcher-made interview guide and an FGD protocol. It is an open-ended question or a semi-structured questions which will be foreshadowed before the actual conduct of the study. Open-ended questions will be prepared to capture the experiences of the visually impaired students in the mainstream education setting.

Data Gathering Procedure

In gathering the data, the researcher will seek first the approval of the university president and the campus administrator of the Capiz State University, Pontevedra Campus where some visually impaired participants are enrolled. Consent from authorities specifically the Person's with Disability Affairs Office (PDAO) under the umbrella of the Department of Social Welfare and Development (DSWD) in the province of Capiz will also be secured for those participants who were already graduates. Approval from the IATF to conduct a small group discussion for the FGD will also be secured to insure the safety of the participants due to pandemic. Once approved, the participants will then be asked to sign the informed consent for their willingness to participate in the study. The content of the informed consent will be discussed thoroughly to the participants to minimize misunderstanding. An interview protocol will be utilized as a guide for the researcher in the conduct of in-depth interview and FGD protocol for the focus group discussion.

In-depth interview will be the primary data gathering method to be used. According to Reinharz (1992), in-depth interview is a form of data collection method that differs from surveys or structured because it encourages "free interaction between the researcher and interviewee" and offers "opportunities for clarification and discussion". The advantage of interviewing is that it has the potential to gather more information than any other method of data collection.

Due to the pandemic, proper health protocol will be followed to insure the safety of the participants involved. Wearing of face masks, faceshields and following a social distancing will be required during the conduct of in-depth interview and focus group discussion (FGD) to the participants.

Moreover, all the proceedings will be recorded and written with the approval of the participants as stated in the informed consent. Interviews can be done using both English and Hiligaynon languages.

Data Analysis Procedure

Data analysis is one of the few facets of doing qualitative research. According to Merriam (2009), the much preferred way to analyze data in a qualitative study is to do it simultaneously with data collection. Simultaneous data collection and analysis occurs both in and out of the field, that is, doing some rudimentary analysis while in the process of collecting data, as well as between data collection activities.

All data and information that will be gathered from the study will be consolidated for transcriptions, organizations, classifications to be able to transform into categories or themes for interpretations. The analyses of interview transcripts will begin from listening to the participants' responses in corroboration with the audio-video recordings and photographs. The raw data will be transcribed in *toto* based on the dialect used by the participants. The data analysis procedure includes coding and the use of NVivo software. Coding is a systematic way for extensive data to be condensed into smaller analyzable units by creating categories and concepts that are derived from the data (Lockyer, 2004). The process of coding includes breaking down, comparing, and categorizing the data, then making connections between categories, and then selecting the core categories, relating themes to other categories, and confirming and explaining the relationships (Lockyer, 2004).

The final product of case study will be a narrative report that will tell the story of the case and enables the readers to fully understand the case from the narrative (Taylor & Thomas Gregory, 2015).

Ethical Considerations

The researcher will send an informed consent to the prospective participants explaining the nature and purpose of the study. They will be assured of the confidentiality of information to ensure that they did not only provide simply socially acceptable responses. Getting the trust and confidence of the

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participants for the researcher to establish good relations is very important before the start of the data collection. Permission to record and capture photos during the fieldworks will be asked from the participants. The data will be kept private and computer data, protected from invasion. The identity of participants will be kept confidential and will be given codenames. Lastly, the participants will be given the chance to review and to amend the transcribed copy of the interview prior to publication.

(14) Major Activities/Work plan

Research Objectives	Year 1											
	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	June	July	Aug	Sept	Oct	Nov	Dec
1. Conceptualization Proposal presentation												
2. Data gathering/Field work/observation												
3. Data Analysis/ interpretation/ Result generating												
4. Lay-outing, Editing and Printing												

(15) Expected Output

Programs or Services that can help the visually impaired students adapt to the pressures of the mainstream education

(15) Technology Transfer Activity Design

Policy/Program/Services

(16) Targets Beneficiaries

Visually impaired students and other PWDs students

(17) Personnel Requirement

Name	Role (Program, Project, Study Leader)	Field of Specialization

Percent time devoted to the Program/ Project/ Study

Program/Project Leader (in hours):

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Program/Project Members (in hours):

(18) Budgetary Requirement

SOURCES OF EXPENSES	Quantity	Amount (PhP)
A. Personnel Services (For studies needed the Research Assistant, informant/s, guide)		
B. Maintenance and Other Operating Expenses (MOOE) (modify and include only whichever is applicable)		
- Transportation allowance		
- Meal allowance during data gathering		
- Professional fees (laboratory analysis and other related fees)		
- Miscellaneous (for incidental expenses)		
- Printing		
C. CAPITAL OUTLAY		
Total		

(19) Literature Cited (include only those references published in reputable journals, and at least that from CAPSU Research Journal, <http://researchjournal.capsu.edu.ph/>)

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(20) Capsule Curriculum Vitae (One-page brief C.V. only)